AAA	Prime
AA	High Grade
A	Upper Medium
BBB	Lower Medium
BB	Speculative
B	Highly Spec.
CCC	Distressed

NOTCHWORK.IO

Shadow ratings in minutes, not weeks.
Published agency frameworks. Zero Big 3 fees.

- → Live product: notchwork.vercel.app
- → S&P & Moody's operational today
- → Upload annual report → full shadow rating in < 10 min
- → Target: mid-market CFOs, DCM bankers, rating advisors
- → Moody's + Fitch on the roadmap — multi-agency vision
- → Raising: £500K–£750K Seed at £3.5M pre-money

Guillaume · Senior IB Professional, London

Studio Tonton Gug · April 2026 · Strictly Confidential

Executive Summary

The full picture in one page

THE GAP

60,000+ mid-market corporates globally need credit insight but are priced out of agency ratings ($75K–$500K+ per engagement). Banks spend weeks on manual scorecards with no methodology backbone.

THE PRODUCT

NotchWork is a live SaaS platform. Upload an annual report → AI extracts financials → applies full S&P methodology (CICRA → BRP/FRP → Anchor → Modifiers → ICR) → outputs scorecard, narrative, sensitivities, PPTX memo. Under 10 minutes.

THE MOAT

18 S&P methodology PDFs ingested via prompt caching + RAG. Every output ties to a specific methodology reference — fully auditable. The technical infrastructure took months to build and years to replicate.

THE MARKET

$8.5B global credit rating market growing 7.2% CAGR. 300,000+ companies priced out of Big 3. No self-service shadow rating product exists today. First mover in an uncontested space.

THE MODEL

SaaS £99–£999/mo + Enterprise API £3K–£20K/mo + White-label rev share. Year 1: 50 clients → £240K ARR. Year 3: 500 clients + 10 enterprise → £1.94M revenue. Series A at £1M+ ARR.

THE ASK

£500K–£750K seed at £3.5M pre-money via SAFE/Convertible Note. 18-month runway: Fitch engine, DBRS, first 50 clients, first hire, Series A readiness at £15M+ pre-money target.

01

The Problem

90% of the market has no credit voice — and the gap is growing

The Credit Rating Gap

A $400B+ advisory market where mid-market is invisible

Agency fees are prohibitive for 99% of companies

S&P initial rating: $75K–$600K+. Annual surveillance: $50K–$300K per agency. Dual-agency program for a £200M mid-cap: £400K–£1M+ over 5 years. The vast majority of potential issuers never get rated.

Banks and advisors are flying blind

DCM teams and corporate advisors spend 2–6 weeks building manual credit scorecards — no standardised methodology, no auditability. Every analyst uses a different Excel model. No shared, defensible output.

CFOs have no independent benchmark

Mid-market CFOs preparing a refinancing, USPP issuance, or PE exit have no credible third-party credit estimate. They guess — or pay £50K–£200K to a boutique for a static, 8-week PDF.

The BBB cliff is a board-level risk

$699B of BBB- rated debt globally — 28% is one notch from high yield. Forced selling, RBC tripling, index exclusion, 100–300 bps spread widening. Companies with no credit monitoring have no early warning system.

Shadow rating advisory is broken

4–8 week delivery. Static PDF output. No scenario analysis, no chatbot, no peer comparison, no ongoing monitoring. £50K–£200K fee for a one-off memo that becomes stale within months.

60K+

Mid-market corps with no external rating

$500K

Max S&P initial fee per program

4–8 wks

Traditional shadow rating timeline

~90%

Global companies with no public rating

$699B

BBB- debt at risk of fallen-angel cliff

£200K

Boutique shadow rating advisory fee

"The rating advisory market is broken — opaque, slow, and reserved for companies with seven-figure budgets. Mid-market issuers deserve the same insight at 1% of the cost."

02

The Solution

NotchWork — live at notchwork.vercel.app. Published methodology. Under 10 minutes.

NotchWork — Live Product

What users experience today at notchwork.vercel.app

"Published agency frameworks, not a black box. Every judgment ties back to a specific methodology reference — so the output is auditable end to end."

STEP 01

Upload your docs

Annual report, 10-K, or 20-F to start. The platform reads the document and pre-fills company identity and financials. Optional: peer rating reports, IMs, investor decks — each sharpens the analysis.

→

STEP 02

Fine-tune with the chatbot

Co-analyst chatbot accepts plain-English answers. Add peers, correct ratios, discuss financial policy. 'My peers are Veolia BBB and Suez BB+.' Skip entirely or go deep — your call.

→

STEP 03

Get a full rating outcome

Scorecard, modifiers, sensitivities, narrative memo, exportable PPTX. S&P & Moody's live today. Fitch, DBRS, Scope, KBRA coming. Every output references the specific methodology page — fully auditable.

```
// S&P Rating Flow – live engine (notchwork.vercel.app)

industry_risk × country_risk → combined_risk   +   competitive_position → business_risk_profile
cash_flow_ratios + leverage → financial_risk_profile   ×   business → anchor   +   modifiers → SACP   +   group/GRE/sovereign → ICR
```

The Methodology Engine

18 S&P PDFs — ingested, cached, and RAG-indexed. Not a black box.

TIER 1 — Core (always cached)

Loaded on every request via prompt caching → 90% token saving

- General Corporate Methodology
- Ratios & Adjustments
- Industry Risk (CICRA)
- Country Risk Assessment
- Management & Governance
- ESG Principles
- Group Rating Methodology
- Liquidity Descriptors

TIER 2 — Sector Overlay

Loaded dynamically based on company sector tag

- Sector-Specific Corporate Methodology
- Sector & Industry Variables (Spec Grade)
- Investment Holding Companies

TIER 3 — Issue-Level (on demand)

Triggered by specific instrument or structure flags

- Hybrid Capital Methodology
- Recovery Rating Criteria
- Subordination Risk
- Ratings Above Sovereign
- Government-Related Entities
- Jurisdiction Assessments

Prompt caching (Tier 1 always hot) + pgvector RAG (Supabase) + Claude Sonnet 4.5 + streaming SSE → < 10 min end-to-end · ~£0.015/rating at scale

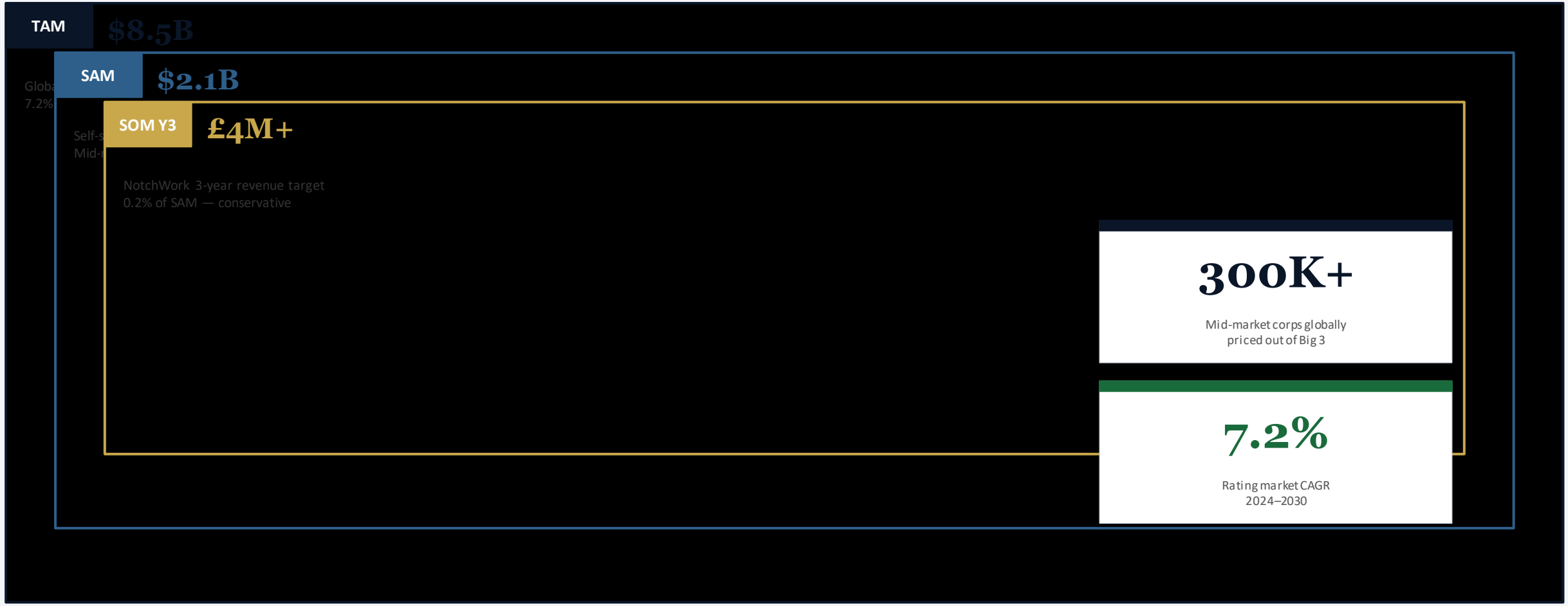
03

Market Opportunity

$8.5B market, 300,000+ underserved — zero direct competitors

Market Size — TAM / SAM / SOM

Three overlapping addressable markets



Why now?

• AI (Claude, RAG) makes methodology automation feasible for the first time • S&P fees hit record highs (+15-20% since 2022) • BBB cliff anxiety at 15-year high
• Private credit boom ($2T+ AUM) creates 300K+ unrated borrowers needing shadow ratings • Post-SVB banks demand more granular credit analysis from clients

04

Business Model

SaaS + Enterprise + White-label — three compounding revenue streams

Business Model — Three Revenue Streams

Recurring SaaS core, enterprise upside, white-label leverage

STREAM 1
SaaS Subscription

Analyst — **£99/mo**

1 user · 5 ratings/month · PDF export · ideal for independent advisors

Professional — **£299/mo**

3 users · unlimited ratings · PPTX export · API access · comps benchmark

Team — **£999/mo**

10 users · priority support · chatbot enrichment · comps DB · white-label output

STREAM 2
Enterprise API

Bank / DCM Team — **£3K–£15K/mo**

Unlimited ratings · white-label output · S&P + Moody's · custom sector benchmarks · SLA

PE / Credit Fund — **£5K–£20K/mo**

Portfolio monitoring · bulk upload · NAIC guidance · real-time alerts · attribution reports

Advisory Boutique — **Rev share 30%**

White-label NotchWork as own IP · client billing stays with boutique · NotchWork earns 30%

STREAM 3
Data & Intelligence

Comps Database — **included Y2+**

Anonymised benchmarks from aggregated platform ratings · sector P25/median/P75 · Supabase

API Data Feeds — **£500/mo**

Bulk shadow rating data exports for systematic fixed income strategies and PE portfolio tools

Research Reports — **one-off £2K–£10K**

Sector credit trend reports for institutional audiences · Utilities · Healthcare · Infrastructure

Financial Projections — 3-Year Plan

Conservative base case · Seed → Series A

	Year 1 (2026)	Year 2 (2027)	Year 3 (2028)
SaaS subscribers	50	200	500
Enterprise clients	0	3	10
SaaS ARR	£96K	£360K	£900K
Enterprise ARR	£0	£120K	£600K
White-label / data	£0	£60K	£240K
Total ARR	**£96K**	**£540K**	**£1.74M**
API + data revenue	£0	£60K	£200K
Total Revenue	**£96K**	**£600K**	**£1.94M**
Gross margin	~80%	~82%	~84%
Net burn	(£420K)	(£280K)	Breakeven+

Unit Economics

SaaS ARPU (blended)	**£160/mo**	£1,920/yr
Enterprise ARPU	**£6K/mo**	£72K/yr
Monthly churn target	**< 5%**	SaaS industry avg 3–8%
CAC (IB channel)	**~£200–£400**	vs £2K+ inbound avg
LTV (24mo, SaaS)	**~£3,840**	LTV/CAC > 10×
Payback period	**< 3 months**	Best-in-class SaaS
Gross margin	**80–84%**	Software benchmark

Key assumption: 1 enterprise contract (£72K ARR) = 100 SaaS subscribers. The enterprise channel is the asymmetric upside — and the founder's IB network is the direct activation path for first enterprise deals.

05

Competition & Moat

White space confirmed. Technical moat built. Clock ticking.

Competitive Landscape

NotchWork occupies uncontested white space

	Self-service?	Published methodology?	Under 10 min?	Under £500/mo?	Chatbot enrichment?	Doc upload → rating?
NotchWork	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
S&P / Moody's / Fitch	✗	✓	✗	✗	✗	◑
Big 3 Platforms (RatingsDirect, MIS)	◑	✓	◑	✗	✗	✗
Rating Advisory Boutiques	✗	✓	✗	✗	◑	✗
S&P Global Market Intelligence	◑	◑	◑	✗	✗	✗
Bloomberg DRSK / Moody's Analytics	◑	◑	◑	✗	✗	✗
RapidRatings / Moody's CreditView	◑	✗	◑	◑	✗	✗
Generic AI (ChatGPT / Gemini)	✓	✗	✓	✓	✓	◑

Why NotchWork wins — and why no one else can replicate it quickly

→ Published S&P methodology (18 PDFs ingested) = auditable, defensible, acceptable to banks and regulators. Generic AI cannot replicate this.

→ Self-service speed (< 10 min) vs boutique advisory (4–8 weeks) and agency (6–12 weeks) — 100× faster, 99% cheaper.

→ Document upload → automatic rating extraction. No Bloomberg terminal, no analyst army required.

→ Chatbot co-analyst = the first interactive shadow rating experience in the market. Peers, ratios, financial policy — all in plain English.

→ Technical moat: prompt caching + RAG + Claude Sonnet = months of engineering already done. Competitors would need 12–18 months to rebuild from scratch.

06

Go-To-Market

IB network first. Content second. Enterprise third.

Go-To-Market Strategy

Three phases, sequenced for capital efficiency

PHASE 1 · Now → Month 6

IB Network — First 25 Clients

- Direct outreach via IB network + EDHEC alumni
- Target: DCM analysts, CFOs preparing bond issuances, rating advisory teams
- Offer: free Professional plan (30 days) → convert to £299/mo paid
- Positioning: 'I build these models in my day job — try it for your next client'
- Week 1 pipeline: 40+ warm contacts already identified

PHASE 2 · Month 6–12

Content + Community

- LinkedIn thought leadership: 'shadow rating of the week' series
- Targeted Google/LinkedIn ads: 'shadow rating', 'S&P methodology', 'credit assessment'
- Partner with 2–3 rating advisory boutiques (referral + white-label deals)
- /rating-introduction hub drives organic SEO — 8 tabs, comprehensive content
- Target: 50 paying clients, £240K ARR run-rate

PHASE 3 · Month 12–18

Enterprise & White-Label

- Package NotchWork as white-label for advisory boutiques (rev share 30%)
- First enterprise bank API contract — 1 deal = £72K ARR (= 100 SaaS subscribers)
- PE / credit fund channel: portfolio monitoring for 100+ unrated borrowers
- USPP-specific module: NAIC designation guidance, Note Purchase Agreement context
- Target: 200 clients, £1.2M ARR, Series A materials prepared

07

Founder & Team

10 years of the problem. Already shipped. Network is the moat.

The Founder — Guillaume

Domain insider × builder × IB network

Guillaume · Founder & CEO

Role:	Corporate Advisory & Transaction Execution — major IB, London
Focus:	Event-driven finance, debt financing advisory, rating advisory — Healthcare & Utilities sectors
Domain depth:	10+ years advising issuers on debt structuring, ratings strategy, and capital markets access — including shadow rating preparation
Rating expertise:	Builds S&P/Moody's shadow rating models in his day job. Knows the methodology gaps, client pain, and bank workflows from the inside.
Education:	EDHEC Business School (Finance)
Builder track record:	3 live products: NotchWork.vercel.app · NewsBeats.vercel.app · Amazon KDP series. Full-stack: Next.js, Claude API, Supabase, Vercel, Python.
Network:	IB network + EDHEC alumni + DCM community = direct activation path for first enterprise clients
Why now:	'I build these models manually at work every week. I know exactly what's missing — and I've already built it.'

5 Unfair Advantages

Domain insider

Does this exact work at a bulge-bracket IB. Built shadow ratings manually. Knows the methodology gaps, the client pain, and the bank DCM workflow from the inside — no competitor can replicate this.

IB distribution ready

Direct warm access to 40+ DCM teams, corporate advisors, and CFOs. First 25 clients require zero paid CAC — just LinkedIn messages to existing contacts.

Builder already shipped

3 live products deployed. NotchWork is not a prototype — it's already live at notchwork.vercel.app. Claude Code, Next.js, Vercel — modern stack.

Technical moat built

18 S&P PDFs ingested. Prompt caching. RAG. Chatbot. PPTX export. Competitors would need 12–18 months of engineering to get here.

First mover — window open

Zero self-service shadow rating products exist globally. The Big 3 won't cannibalize themselves. This window belongs to an AI-native builder.

Seed hire plan: 1 product/growth hire at Month 6 (£60K budget)

08

The Ask

£500K–£750K Seed · £3.5M pre-money · 18 months to Series A

The Ask — Seed Round

Terms, use of funds, and milestones

Round Terms

Raise:	**£500K – £750K**
Instrument:	**SAFE / Convertible Note**
Pre-money valuation:	**£3.5M**
Post-money (£750K close):	**£4.25M**
Equity offered:	**~15–18%**
Use period:	**18 months**
Series A trigger:	**£1M+ ARR run-rate**

Use of Funds

Product (Fitch/DBRS engines, comps DB, mobile)	40%
Go-to-market (first 50 clients, outreach)	30%
Team (first hire — Month 6, product/growth)	20%
Legal, IP protection, compliance	10%

18-Month Milestones

Month 1–2	**Seed close + Supabase**	Fix GitHub secrets, complete doc upload pipeline, Fitch engine initiated
Month 3	**Fitch engine live**	S&P + Moody's + Fitch · tri-agency output · split rating comparison
Month 4–5	**First 10 paying clients**	IB network outreach · onboarding feedback loop · iterate fast
Month 6	**First hire**	Product/growth · Fitch engine initiated · white-label pipeline opened
Month 8	**50 clients, £240K ARR**	Enterprise API v1 · first bank conversations · comps DB seeding
Month 10	**First enterprise contract**	1 bank deal = £72K ARR · validates enterprise thesis fully
Month 12	**Comps DB + USPP module**	100+ anonymised ratings · NAIC guidance · portfolio monitoring v1
Month 15	**200 clients, £1.2M ARR**	Series A materials prepared · 18-month proof of product-market fit
Month 18	**Series A raise**	Target: £3–5M at £15M+ pre-money · full multi-agency platform

Why Now — 5 Forces Creating the Window

A once-in-a-decade confluence of market, technology, and regulation

1 AI crossed the threshold in 2024

Claude's 200K-token context + prompt caching makes ingesting 18 complex methodology PDFs feasible at ~£0.015/rating. 18 months ago this unit economics was impossible. The window opened in 2024.

2 BBB cliff anxiety is at a 15-year high

$699B of BBB- rated debt, 28% one notch from HY, $387B on negative outlook. CFOs, boards, and lenders have never been more focused on real-time credit positioning. Demand has never been higher.

3 S&P fees hit record highs in 2025

S&P raised rack rate from 6.95 to 7.90 bps, minimum from $125K to $140K. The mid-market affordability gap is widening. A new, newly-frustrated buyer segment is being pushed out of the market.

4 Private credit boom = 300K+ unrated borrowers

Private credit AUM exceeded $2T in 2025. Virtually all private credit borrowers are unrated. PE sponsors, direct lenders, and CLO managers need shadow ratings for NAIC designation, LP reporting, and risk monitoring.

5 — No one has moved — the window is wide open: Despite the obvious gap, zero self-service shadow rating products exist. The Big 3 won't cannibalize themselves. Boutique advisors can't automate. Only an AI-native builder can move — and we're already live.

Product Roadmap — 18 Months

Seed → Moody's → 50 clients → Enterprise → Series A

NOW — Seed Close	Q3 2026 — Fitch + DBRS	Q4 2026 — Platform Scale	Q1–Q2 2027 — Series A Prep
✓ S&P engine live	→ Fitch methodology + VR for banks	→ Fitch methodology	→ Scope Ratings integration
✓ Doc upload pipeline	→ DBRS Morningstar integration	→ Comps DB public	→ KBRA / AM Best / Fitch VR
✓ Chatbot co-analyst	→ Tri-agency + split rating output	→ FMP/EDGAR data layer	→ NAIC / USPP module
✓ PPTX / PDF export	→ Enterprise API v1	→ White-label v1	→ Multi-user teams
✓ 8-tab rating hub	→ First 25 clients	→ 50 clients, £240K ARR	→ 200 clients, £1.2M ARR
✓ Vercel + GitHub CI	→ Comps DB seeding	→ First enterprise deal	→ Series A close

Seed close → Moody's (M3) → 50 clients / £240K ARR (M8) → Enterprise contract (M10) → Series A ready (M18) · 18-month burn from £750K raise

Appendix — Technology Stack

Built on modern, scalable, cost-efficient infrastructure

Frontend

- Next.js 14 (App Router) + TypeScript
- Tailwind CSS + shadcn/ui components
- Clerk authentication (social login, JWT)
- Streaming Server-Sent Events (SSE) for real-time output

AI Engine

- Claude Sonnet 4.5 (Anthropic) via API
- Prompt caching: Tier 1 PDFs always hot
- RAG: Supabase pgvector (1536-dim embeddings)
- Multi-turn chatbot with session state

Backend & Data

- Supabase (PostgreSQL + pgvector + auth)
- 5 core tables: methodology_chunks, rating_sessions, session_documents, comps_database, chat_messages
- Keep-alive GitHub Action (Mondays & Thursdays)
- EODHD + FMP APIs for public comps data

Infrastructure

- Vercel (frontend + serverless API routes)
- GitHub Actions (CI/CD + keep-alive cron)
- Cloudflare R2 (document storage)
- PptxGenJS (dynamic PPTX generation)

Cost at scale: ~£0.015/rating (prompt caching) · ~£30/mo Supabase · ~£0/mo Vercel Hobby → Total infra cost at 50 users: ~£50–60/mo

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Raising £500K–£750K Seed · £3.5M pre-money · 18 months to Series A

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